IELTS Momentum

Elite IELTS 7.0+ · Band 6.0–6.5 to 7.0+

Student's Book · Week 4: Crime and punishment

An IELTSflow Signature Course. All texts and tasks in this book are original IELTSflow material.

This week

Listening: Section 4 note completion – dense lectures. **Speaking:** natural collocations and idioms (not forced ones).

Reading: summary completion with a word box. **Writing:** Task 1 tables with many categories – grouping.

Grammar: concession and contrast. **Sunday:** MOCK 4.

Week 4 · Lesson 1 Listening + Speaking

Topic: Right and wrong · **Vocabulary for IELTS Advanced:** Unit 25 (IELTS Speaking) · **Exam focus:** Listening Section 4 – note completion; Speaking – collocation and idiomatic language

1 Warm-up: how serious is it? (8 min)

In threes, rank these from **least** to **most** serious. Then compare with another group and agree a fair punishment for the top two.

1 Downloading a film illegally
2 Driving 20 km/h over the speed limit
3 Not paying for a bus ticket
4 Writing graffiti on a school wall
5 Lying on a CV to get a job
6 Keeping a wallet you found in the street

2 Vocabulary: idiomatic language for speaking

Word / phrase	Definition	Example
turn a blind eye (to)	to pretend not to notice something wrong	Some shopkeepers **turn a blind eye to** underage smoking.
get away with (sth)	to do something wrong and not be punished	He **got away with** cheating in the exam.
a slap on the wrist	a punishment that is too mild	A small fine is just **a slap on the wrist** for a big company.
the tip of the iceberg	a small, visible part of a much bigger problem	Reported cases are only **the tip of the iceberg**.
take the law into your own hands	to punish someone yourself instead of going to the police	Angry residents **took the law into their own hands**.
learn your lesson	to understand that you should not do something again	After the fine, he **learned his lesson**.
set an example	to behave in a way that others should copy	Parents should **set an example** by obeying traffic rules.
crack down on	to deal with a problem much more strictly	Police are **cracking down on** speeding.

Word / phrase	Definition	Example
think twice	to consider something very carefully before doing it	High fines make drivers **think twice**.
go off the rails	to start behaving badly or in an unacceptable way	He **went off the rails** after leaving school.
fall in with the wrong crowd	to become friends with people who are a bad influence	She **fell in with the wrong crowd** at 15.
peer pressure	influence from people of your own age to behave like them	**Peer pressure** is a major cause of youth crime.
petty crime	minor crime, such as small thefts	**Petty crime** has fallen in the city centre.
give someone a second chance	to allow someone to try again after a mistake	Employers should **give** ex-prisoners **a second chance**.
on the right side of the law	obeying the law	Sport helps keep teenagers **on the right side of the law**.

Natural, not forced

Band 7 asks for **'some less common and idiomatic vocabulary'** used with **awareness of style and collocation**. Band 8 asks for it to be used **skilfully**.

× Forced: *Crime is a hot potato, and it's raining cats and dogs of problems.* (old-fashioned, wrong meaning, wrong place)

✓ Natural: A small fine is really just **a slap on the wrist** for a big company, so they don't **think twice** about breaking the rules.

Rule: one idiom per answer is plenty. Use it only when it fits the meaning **exactly**.

Group work

Idiom experts: Pair A teaches items 1–8, Pair B items 9–15. For each, give a **situation** where it fits naturally.

Natural or forced? Your teacher reads 8 answers. Teams hold up a green card (natural) or a red card (forced) and must explain why.

Practice. Complete with an expression from the list in the correct form.

1 Reported cybercrime is only ……; most victims never tell the police.

2 If the police ……. minor offences, people start to think the rules don't matter.

3 He was caught shoplifting, but he ……. and never did it again.

4 The new cameras have made drivers ……. before speeding.

5 Celebrities who break the law should be punished, because they need to …….

6 After his parents divorced, he ……. and started missing school.

7 The government is ……. illegal parking in the city centre.

8 Instead of calling the police, the neighbours …….

3 Listening (20 min)

Listening slot: Cambridge IELTS 16, Test 1, Part 4 (note completion)

Section 4 is a lecture with no break. You have about 45 seconds to read 10 questions – use them to predict and to notice the **headings** in the notes.

The headings are your map. When the speaker says *Moving on to …, Turning now to …, Another aspect …*, look at the next heading.

Answers are often short nouns that follow a definition or example: *what the Stoics called …, a practice known as …*

Group work

Prediction pairs (4 min): for each gap, write the **word type** and **one guess**. Compare with another pair.

After (8 min): in threes, compare answers and spelling. Then, with the transcript, each person finds **two** signposting phrases that told them a new heading was starting.

Lecture summary: as a team, retell the lecture in 60 seconds using only your notes.

4 Speaking: Parts 1 and 3 with natural language

Group work

Part 1 speed rounds: inner and outer circle, 2 minutes per pair, then move. Use **at least one** expression from the list in each round – your partner must not notice it was forced!

Part 3 debate pairs: two pairs face each other. Pair A argues for **stricter punishment**, Pair B for **rehabilitation**. Each speaker answers in 4–6 sentences (A–R–E–A+).

Part 1: Rules	Part 3: Crime and society

Did your school have many rules? Have you ever broken a rule? Are there any rules you think are unnecessary? Are people in your country good at following traffic rules?	Why do some young people commit crimes? Is prison the best way to deal with criminals? Should parents be punished for their children's crimes? Can technology prevent crime? How?

Week 4 · Lesson 2 Reading + Writing

Topic: Law enforcement · **Vocabulary for IELTS Advanced:** Unit 18 · **Exam focus:** Reading – summary completion with a word box, True / False / Not Given; Writing Task 1 – tables

1 Vocabulary: law enforcement (12 min)

Word / phrase	Definition	Example
law enforcement	the work of making sure laws are obeyed, e.g. by the police	**Law enforcement** agencies share information.
offender	a person who has committed a crime	Young **offenders** are kept in separate prisons.
reoffend / reoffending	to commit another crime after being punished	Education reduces **reoffending**.
custodial sentence	a punishment that involves time in prison	Minor offenders rarely receive a **custodial sentence**.
community service	unpaid work for the community as a punishment	He did 200 hours of **community service**.
rehabilitate / rehabilitation	to help an offender return to normal life	Prisons should **rehabilitate**, not only punish.
deter / deterrent	to discourage someone from doing something / a thing that does this	Cameras **deter** thieves.
convict / conviction	to officially find someone guilty / such a decision	He was **convicted** of fraud.
acquit	to officially find someone not guilty	The jury **acquitted** her of all charges.
surveillance	the careful watching of people, e.g. by cameras	Many cities use video **surveillance**.
minor offence	a crime that is not serious	Dropping litter is a **minor offence**.
juvenile	relating to young people under 18	**Juvenile** crime rose last year.
vandalism	deliberate damage to public or private property	**Vandalism** costs councils millions.

Word / phrase	Definition	Example
zero tolerance	a policy of punishing every offence, however small	The school has a **zero-tolerance** policy on bullying.
disorder	a situation where people behave badly and break rules	Signs of **disorder** can encourage further crime.

Group work

Justice line: in fours, put these in the order they happen: *commit an offence* ➜ … ➜ *reoffend* using: convict, custodial sentence, rehabilitation, surveillance, acquit, offender. Can one person's story include all of them?

Opposites race: find pairs or contrasts in the list (*convict / acquit, custodial sentence / community service*). First team to find four wins.

Practice. Choose the correct word.

1 After a two-week trial, the jury (acquitted / convicted) him, so he walked free.

2 Many experts believe prison does little to (deter / rehabilitate) offenders who are already addicted to drugs.

3 First-time offenders are often given (community service / zero tolerance) instead of prison.

4 Rates of (reoffending / surveillance) are highest among young men.

5 Cameras on every corner have raised concerns about (surveillance / disorder).

6 The court treats (juvenile / custodial) offenders differently from adults.

2 Reading: Passage 2–3 level

Exam strategy: summary completion with a word box

1 The box has **more words than gaps** – usually words of the **same type**, so grammar alone won't help.

2 Read the summary first and decide which **part of the text** it covers (summaries often follow 1–3 paragraphs in order).

3 The summary uses **paraphrases**: the box word may not appear in the text at all (*neglect* for *signs that nobody cares*).

4 Check **meaning and logic**, not just grammar: *a car in a …… area* – wealthy or poor? What does the text say?

Group work

Predict the gaps (4 min): in pairs, read both summaries before the text. For each gap, choose **two** possible words from the box.

Solo exam work (20 min): answer Questions 1–13 alone.

Paraphrase hunt: in threes, for each summary gap, find the phrase in the text that the box word **paraphrases**. Write the pairs on the board.

You should spend about 20 minutes on Questions 1–13, which are based on the reading passage below.

Fixing broken windows

Does tackling minor disorder prevent serious crime? Few ideas in criminology have been so influential, or so controversial.

In 1969, the Stanford University psychologist Philip Zimbardo carried out a simple field experiment. He left one car without number plates and with its bonnet raised in a street in the Bronx, New York, and a similar car in a wealthy neighbourhood of Palo Alto, California. In the Bronx, people began removing parts from the car within minutes, and within days it had been stripped of almost everything of value. In Palo Alto, the car remained untouched for more than a week – until Zimbardo himself smashed part of it with a sledgehammer. Soon afterwards, passers-by joined in, and the vehicle was quickly wrecked. Zimbardo's conclusion was that once a sign of neglect appears, the normal restraints on behaviour begin to weaken, even in a respectable community.

Thirteen years later, the experiment inspired one of the most influential articles in the history of criminology. In 1982, the political scientist James Q. Wilson and the criminologist George Kelling published 'Broken Windows' in the American magazine The Atlantic. Their argument was that visible signs of disorder – a broken window that is not repaired, graffiti, litter, aggressive begging – send a message that nobody is in control. Law-abiding residents begin to avoid public spaces, informal social control weakens, and the area becomes more attractive to serious offenders. If a single broken window is left unrepaired, they suggested, all the other windows will soon be broken too. The solution, therefore, was for police to pay attention not only to serious crime but also to the minor offences that most forces had traditionally ignored.

The theory was put into practice most famously in New York City. In 1990, William Bratton became head of the city's transit police and began a campaign against fare evasion and graffiti on the subway, a system that had become notorious for crime. In 1994, he was appointed commissioner of the New York Police Department by the newly elected mayor, Rudolph Giuliani, and the approach was extended across the city. Officers were instructed to act against offences such as public drinking, minor vandalism and the aggressive washing of car windscreens at traffic lights. Over the same period, crime in New York fell dramatically: the number of murders dropped from

more than 2,200 in 1990 to fewer than 700 in 1998. To many politicians, the link seemed obvious, and versions of the strategy were soon adopted by police forces in other countries.

Researchers, however, were far less certain. Crime fell sharply across the United States during the 1990s, including in cities that had not adopted broken-windows policing, which suggested that other factors – a growing economy, changes in the market for illegal drugs and an increase in the number of police officers – might be at least as important. Some studies found a modest effect of order-maintenance policing on certain crimes; others found none. Disentangling the causes of a nationwide trend from the effect of one city's policy has proved extremely difficult, and the debate among criminologists has never been fully resolved.

More convincing evidence for the basic psychological idea came from a series of experiments conducted in the Dutch city of Groningen and published in the journal Science in 2008. Kees Keizer and his colleagues attached advertising leaflets to the handlebars of bicycles parked in an alley next to a wall where a sign clearly prohibited graffiti. When the wall was clean, 33% of cyclists dropped the leaflet on the ground rather than taking it with them. When the wall had been covered with graffiti, the figure rose to 69%. Similar effects were found in other situations: people were more likely to break one rule when they saw that a different rule had already been broken. Disorder, it seemed, really could be contagious, although the experiments involved minor misbehaviour rather than serious crime.

Critics have also questioned how the theory was applied. In practice, a focus on minor offences in New York became closely associated with 'stop-and-frisk', a practice in which officers stopped and searched large numbers of people, the great majority of them young Black and Hispanic men. Most of those stopped had done nothing wrong. In 2013, a federal judge ruled that the way the city had used the practice violated the constitutional rights of many residents. Kelling himself later argued that the original idea had been misunderstood, and that tackling disorder had never been meant to mean arresting as many people as possible for minor offences.

Indeed, some of the most promising applications of the theory involve no arrests at all. Several studies have found that cleaning up vacant land, repairing abandoned buildings and improving street lighting can reduce crime in the surrounding area, sometimes at a very low cost. Such findings suggest that the central insight of 'Broken Windows' – that the physical condition of a neighbourhood influences how people behave in it – may be correct, even if the aggressive policing carried out in its name was not the most effective, or the fairest, way to act on it.

Questions 1–7

Complete the summaries using the list of words, **A–K**, below.

In Zimbardo's experiment, a car left in a (1) ……. area remained (2) ……. for days, until a sign of damage appeared. Wilson and Kelling later argued that small signs of (3) ……. encourage more crime, so police should not ignore (4) ……. offences.

The fall in crime in the 1990s may have been caused by other factors, such as a stronger (5) ……. Keizer's experiments suggested that disorder may be (6) ……., and other studies show that physical (7) ……. to neighbourhoods can reduce crime without any arrests.

A minor B economy C untouched D arrests E serious F repairs
G contagious H neglect I wealthy J residents K violence

Questions 8–13

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage? Write **TRUE**, **FALSE** or **NOT GIVEN**.

8 In Palo Alto, members of the public damaged the car before Zimbardo did. ____

9 Wilson and Kelling's article was first published in a scientific journal. ____

10 Bratton's first campaign focused on crime on the subway. ____

11 Murders in New York fell by more than two-thirds between 1990 and 1998. ____

12 Most of the cyclists in Groningen were students. ____

13 Kelling agreed that the way his idea was applied in New York was correct. ____

Group work

Discussion (4 min): Would 'fixing broken windows' work in your city? Which **one** cheap change would make your neighbourhood safer? Agree as a team.

3 Writing Task 1: tables with many categories

Band 7 tables: group, don't list

A table with 7 rows and 3 columns has **21 numbers**. Band 5–6 reports list them row by row. Band 7+ reports **group** categories that behave in the same way.

Step 1. Find the groups: which categories **rose**, which **fell**, which stayed **stable**? Which is **biggest / smallest**?

Step 2. Overview: the main groups + the most striking change. **Step 3.** Body 1 = one group, Body 2 = the other group(s).

Step 4. Select: give the start and end figures for each category in a group, but don't describe every middle year.

Recorded crimes per 100,000 people in Country Y, 2005–2025

Type of crime	2005	2015	2025
Burglary	820	610	390
Vehicle theft	540	300	150
Vandalism	650	480	360
Shoplifting	410	450	520
Robbery	120	110	105
Assault	300	290	310
Online fraud	40	380	960

Group work

Sorting game (6 min): in pairs, cut-and-sort (or draw) the seven crimes into groups. Give each group a **name** (*traditional property crime, …*).

Two teams, two plans: Team A plans paragraphs by **trend**; Team B by **type of crime**. Each team presents its plan. Which is clearer?

Overview race: write the overview in 3 minutes; the best one goes on the board.

Language for grouping	Example
Naming a group	**Crimes against property**, such as burglary and vehicle theft, …
Same trend	**All three** fell steadily · **Both** categories rose **by a similar margin** · **The same pattern** can be seen in …

Type of crime	2005	2015	2025
Exception	**The only exception was** shoplifting, which … · **In contrast to** this downward trend, …		
Stable data	remained **broadly stable** at around 300 · changed **only marginally** · **fluctuated slightly**		

Task. Write the full report (20 minutes, at least 150 words).

The table shows the number of recorded crimes per 100,000 people in Country Y in 2005, 2015 and 2025. Summarise the information by selecting and reporting the main features, and make comparisons where relevant.

Week 4 · Lesson 3 Grammar + Writing clinic + Speaking clinic

Grammar: Concession and contrast · **Vocabulary Files C2:** Unit 4, Crime and punishment · **Accuracy:** Common Mistakes at Proficiency, Units 7–8

1 Warm-up: crime collocations (8 min)

Word / phrase	Definition	Example
commit an offence	to do something illegal	He **committed** his first **offence** at 16.
plead guilty	to say in court that you did the crime	She **pleaded guilty** to theft.
serve a sentence	to spend the time in prison given by a court	He **served** a five-year **sentence**.
be released on parole	to be let out of prison early on condition of good behaviour	He **was released on parole** after three years.
a life sentence	the punishment of staying in prison for life (or a very long time)	The murderer received **a life sentence**.
a hardened criminal	a person who has committed many crimes and is unlikely to change	Prison can turn young offenders into **hardened criminals**.
a crime wave	a sudden increase in crime	The city suffered **a crime wave** in the 1980s.
white-collar crime	crime by professionals, e.g. fraud	**White-collar crime** is rarely punished severely.
the death penalty	punishment by death	Many countries have abolished **the death penalty**.
a miscarriage of justice	a situation in which an innocent person is punished	He spent ten years in prison because of **a miscarriage of justice**.

Group work

Courtroom story: in fours, tell the story of one imaginary case from the crime to the end of the sentence, using as many collocations as possible. One person is the 'judge' and stops the story if a collocation is wrong.

2 Grammar: concession and contrast

Group work

Discovery (5 min): compare A *Although prison is expensive, it protects the public.* and B Expensive **as** it is, prison protects the public. / C Prison protects the public, **albeit** at a high cost. Which is most formal? Which could you use in an essay?

Structure	Example
although / even though + clause	**Even though** crime fell, people felt less safe.
despite / in spite of + noun / -ing / the fact that	**Despite the fact that** crime fell, … · **Despite falling**, crime …
while / whereas (contrast)	Burglary fell, **whereas** online fraud soared.
much as + clause (= although, for feelings)	**Much as** I understand their anger, revenge is not justice.
adjective / adverb + as / though + clause	**Strange as it may seem**, harsher sentences do not always deter crime.
albeit + adjective / adverb / phrase	Crime fell, **albeit** slowly. · a small, **albeit** important, change
notwithstanding (formal = despite)	**Notwithstanding** these problems, the policy was a success.
Admittedly / Granted, … However, …	**Admittedly**, prisons protect the public. **However**, they rarely rehabilitate.

Rules and warnings

1 *Despite / in spite of* are **prepositions**: × *Despite crime fell* ☑ *Despite the fall in crime / Despite the fact that crime fell*.

2 Don't use **although … but** in the same sentence (a common Uzbek / Russian transfer: *хотя …, но …*): × *Although it is cheap, but it works.*

3 *Albeit* is followed by a **word or phrase**, not a full clause: × *albeit it was slow*.

4 In *Strange as it may seem*, the adjective comes **first** and there is **no** *so*: × *As strange it may seem*.

Exercise 1. Rewrite each sentence using the word in brackets.

1 Although the fine was small, it changed his behaviour. (despite)

_____

_____

2 Crime rates have fallen, but only slightly. (albeit)

_____

_____

3 Although I sympathise with victims, I oppose the death penalty. (much as)

_____

_____

4 It may seem surprising, but most prisoners are released within two years. (surprising as)

_____

_____

5 Prisons are expensive. However, they protect the public. (admittedly)

_____

_____

6 In spite of these difficulties, the scheme was successful. (notwithstanding)

_____

_____

Exercise 2. Find and correct the mistake.

1 Despite crime fell, people felt less safe.

2 Although the police worked hard, but they caught nobody.

3 The result was positive, albeit it was small.

4 Even crime has fallen, many people are still afraid.

5 As serious the problem is, it can be solved.

Group work

Concession tennis: A makes a claim (*Prison works.*); B must 'return' it with a concession structure (*Much as it protects the public, it rarely changes behaviour.*). Use a different structure each time – repeat one and you lose the point.

3 Writing clinic: Task 1 tables + Mock 3

Peer review – Task 1 band 7 checklist

☐ The categories are **grouped**, not described one by one.

☐ The overview names the groups and the **most striking** change – with no numbers.

☐ Each body paragraph covers **one group**; the exception is clearly signalled.

☐ Numbers are accurate and include the **year** (*from 820 in 2005 to 390 in 2025*).

☐ At least one concession or contrast structure (*whereas, albeit, in contrast to*).

Group work

Swap and score: swap reports, tick the checklist, give a Task Achievement band (6 or 7) with **one** reason.

Mock 3 error clinic: in threes, choose your three worst sentences from Mock 3 writing and fix them together. Share the best correction with the class.

4 Speaking clinic: Parts 2 and 3

Describe a time when you saw someone break a rule.

You should say:

- where and when it happened
- what rule they broke
- what happened as a result

and explain how you felt about it.

Group work

Triads: candidate, examiner, observer. The candidate gives the talk (S–P–T–R) and answers two Part 3 questions from Lesson 1. The observer counts the **natural** idioms and collocations and notes **one** that sounded forced. Swap roles.

5 Accuracy slot: Common Mistakes at Proficiency, Units 7–8

Group work

Be the teacher: each pair corrects two sentences and explains the mistake to the class in one sentence.

1 The police has arrested two men in connection with the robbery.
2 He was accused for stealing a car.
3 The judge sentenced him for five years in prison.
4 She denied to take the money.
5 The crime rate have risen sharply this year.
6 Two men robbed £500 from the shop.

Week 4 · Homework (3–4 hours a day)

Day	Tasks
Day 1 (after L1)	Vocabulary for IELTS Advanced Unit 25 · Record answers to the four Part 3 questions using one idiom per answer (naturally!) · Cambridge IELTS 17 Listening Section 4 + signposting log
Day 2	Cambridge IELTS 17: one Reading passage with a summary task (20 min) · paraphrase log · 10 sentences with this week's words
Day 3 (after L2)	Vocabulary for IELTS Advanced Unit 18 · **Writing: the table below (20 min, 150+ words)**
Day 4	Grammar Exercise 3 · Record the Part 2 + 3 set below and send it · Reading: one passage + paraphrase log
Day 5 (after L3)	Rewrite your crime-table report · Vocabulary Files C2 Unit 4 · Common Mistakes at Proficiency Units 7–8
Day 6	Review all 40 words and expressions · Rest before **MOCK 4** on Sunday

Writing Task 1 (homework)

The table shows the percentage of offenders in Country Y who committed another crime within two years, by age group and type of sentence. Summarise the information by selecting and reporting the main features, and make comparisons where relevant.

Reoffending within two years (%), by age group and type of sentence

Age group	Prison: under 1 year	Prison: 1 year or more	Community service	Fine
18–24	62	48	38	30
25–39	51	40	31	22
40 and over	34	27	19	12

Grammar Exercise 3. Write six sentences about crime and punishment using: despite the fact that · much as · albeit · Strange as it may seem · notwithstanding · Admittedly … However …

Speaking Part 2 + Part 3 (record and send)

Describe a law in your country that you think is good.

You should say:

- what the law is
- when it was introduced (if you know)
- who it protects

and explain why you think it is a good law.

Then answer: (1) Why do some people ignore laws? (2) Should punishments be the same for rich and poor people? (3) Is it better to prevent crime or to punish it?